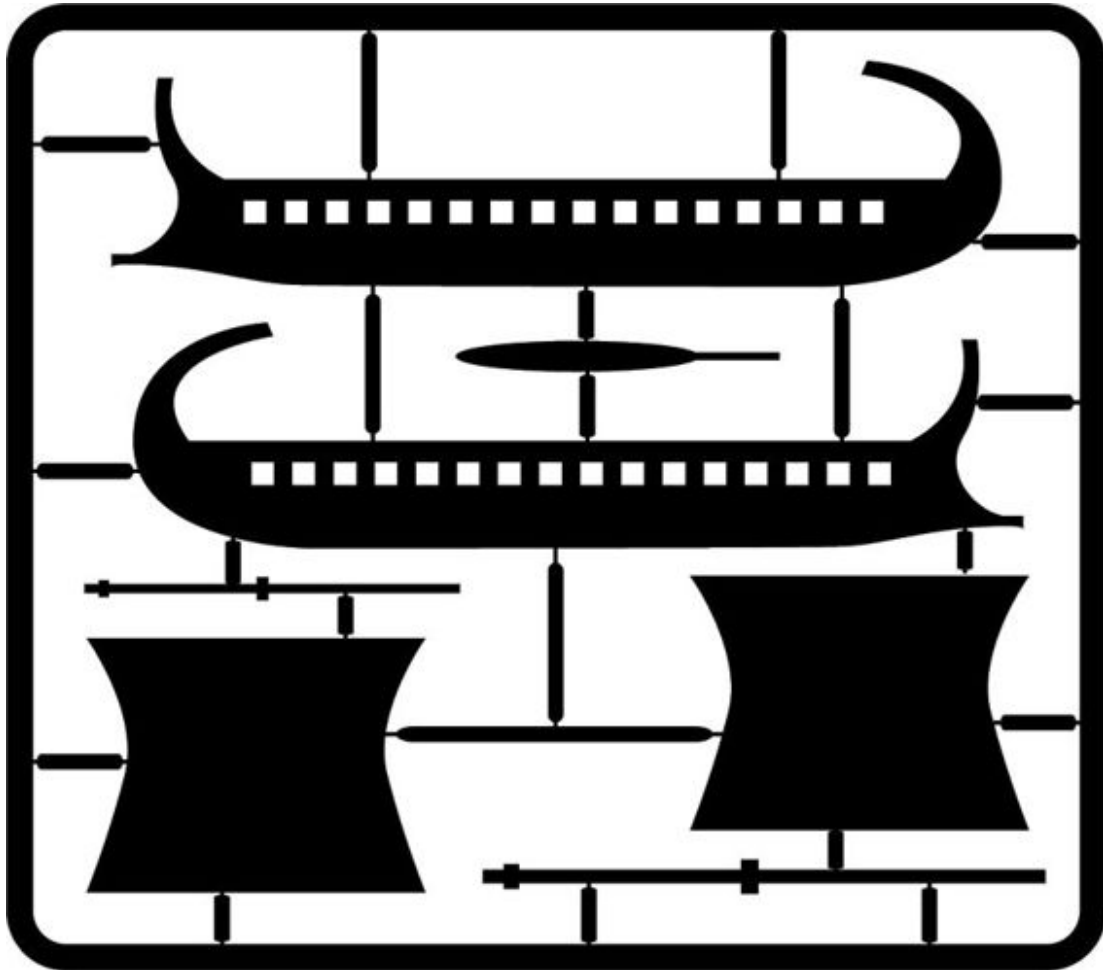


Identity



Does the Ship of Theseus have an identity independent of its component parts?

A carpenter has a favourite hammer that he has used for 50 years, with only two new heads and three new handles. Obviously, it is not the same hammer he started out with – or is it? This is a variation of the old tale of the Ship of Theseus, which underwent repairs throughout its lifetime until nothing original remained, yet still retained its identity.

Human beings go through a similar process of ‘running repairs’, gradually replacing the cells of our bodies so that our physical make-up is completely different after a few years, yet we feel we are still the same person. It seems then that it is our minds, the immaterial substance that Cartesian dualism

proposes, that determine our identities – or at least our knowledge, experience and memory. Suppose, however, that it was possible to make a clone of yourself and transfer your thoughts and memories into its brain; to the outside world it would be indistinguishable from you, and would have every attribute of your identity, but intuitively we know that it is not *actually* you.